

# A PLACE OF YOUR OWN

And that's where the family stronghold comes into play. First, you must be able to get there. When we were confronted with the Y2K crisis more than a decade ago, we lived in Paris. Maybe the French bureaucrats would be able to maintain order, and maybe they wouldn't. We kept our tank full of gas, just in case. It took only one tank of gas to get out to our country house. We figured we'd wait for the desperate mobs to leave the streets. Then we'd drive out of the city and make our way to the country. Once there, we had food stockpiled in the pantry and firewood ricked up to the eaves in the barn. There were cattle on the hoof in the fields and chickens in the henhouse.

Your stronghold should be a place where you can live almost indefinitely on local resources. It doesn't mean you have to have everything you need on your own property. But you have what it takes to trade with your friends and neighbors to get what you need. You may have to barter for a cow or vegetables with the local farmers, for example. You may have to improvise with tools and machinery. You will almost certainly get your hands dirty. And you should keep on hand some small gold and silver coins. They could be useful.

Of course, your standard of living will surely go down, at least in money terms. But it could be fun. Some people actually yearn for simpler, more "authentic" lives. Some find genuine satisfaction in small community life, with heavy emphasis on self-sufficiency and survival skills. As for us, we're never happier than when we're cutting firewood or planting a garden. Keep your laptops and your hard drives. Give us a wrench and a hammer! Dining *al fresco* on *dinde aux groseilles* at a fancy restaurant is fine, but we're just as happy eating a turkey sandwich outside in the yard.

A breakdown in complex civilization? Bring it on!

Since the beginning of the twentieth century, many people have gone to bed hungry. Tens of millions have died of starvation. But almost all the deaths can be traced to the murderous intentions or incompetent administration of governments. In this regard, as in many others, the Soviet Union and China were world leaders. Goofy theories and bad policies